Chapter 1

Computer Abstractions and Technology

The Computer Revolution

- Progress in computer technology
  - Underpinned by domain-specific accelerators
- Makes novel applications feasible
  - Computers in automobiles
  - Cell phones
  - Human genome project
  - World Wide Web
  - Search Engines
- Computers are pervasive

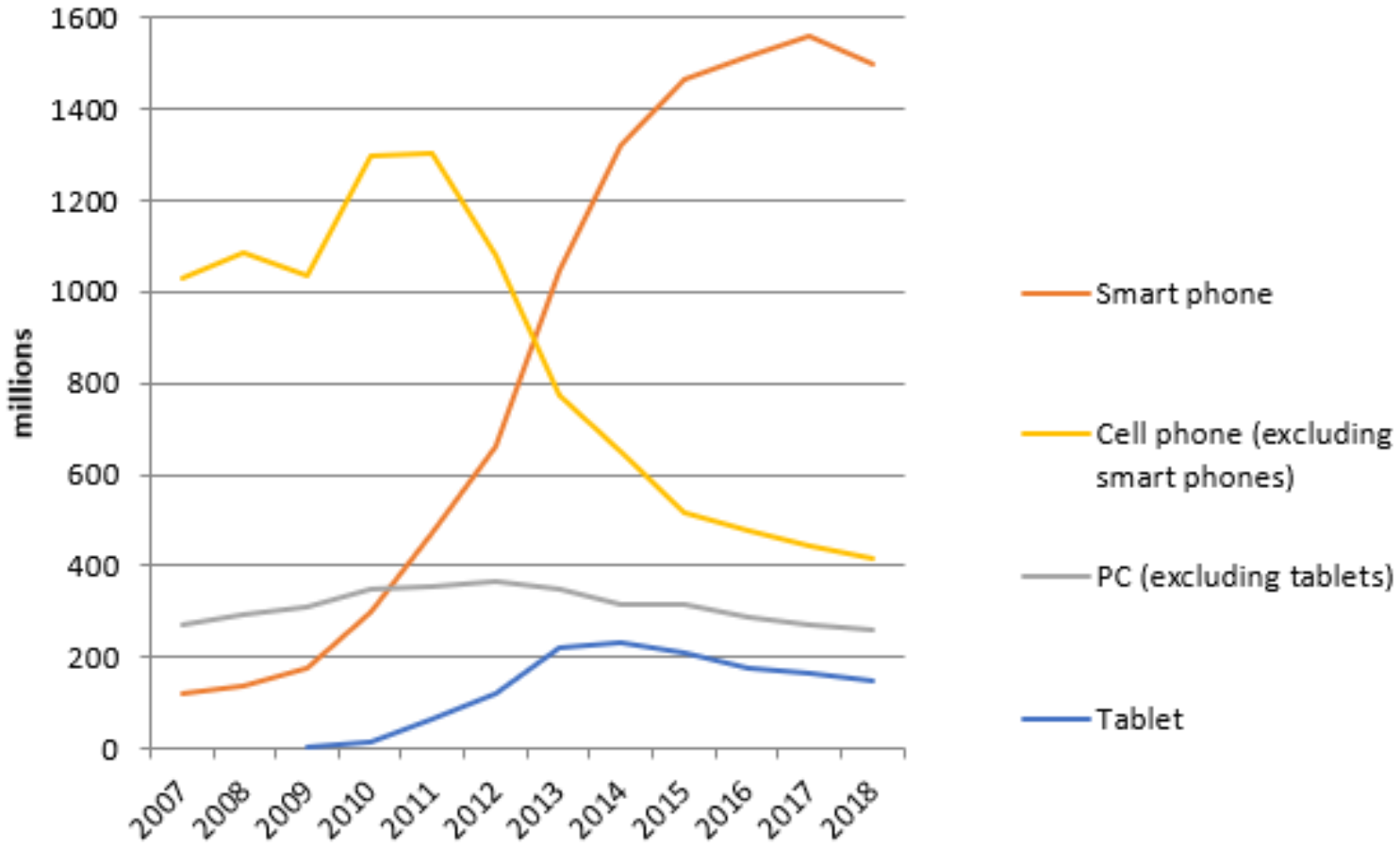
Classes of Computers

- Personal computers
  - General purpose, variety of software
  - Subject to cost/performance tradeoff
- Server computers
  - Network based
  - High capacity, performance, reliability
  - Range from small servers to building sized

Classes of Computers

- Supercomputers
  - Type of server
  - High-end scientific and engineering calculations
  - Highest capability but represent a small fraction of the overall computer market
- Embedded computers
  - Hidden as components of systems
  - Stringent power/performance/cost constraints

The PostPC Era



The PostPC Era

- Personal Mobile Device (PMD)
  - Battery operated
  - Connects to the Internet
  - Hundreds of dollars
  - Smart phones, tablets, electronic glasses
- Cloud computing
  - Warehouse Scale Computers (WSC)
  - Software as a Service (SaaS)
  - Portion of software run on a PMD and a portion run in the Cloud
  - Amazon and Google

What You Will Learn

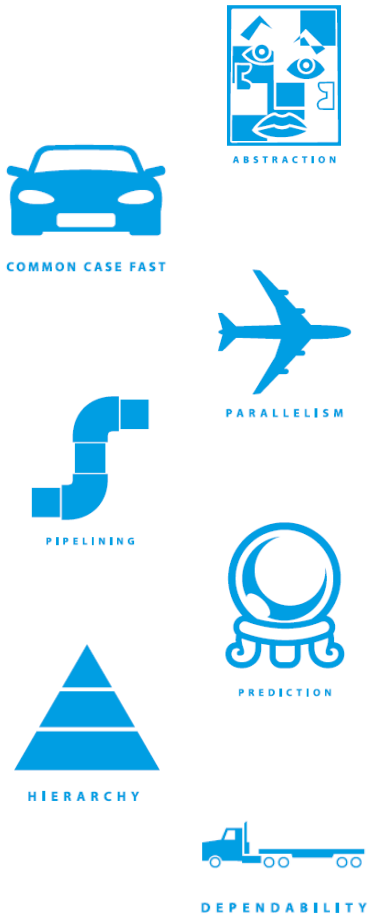
- How programs are translated into the machine language
  - And how the hardware executes them
- The hardware/software interface
- What determines program performance
  - And how it can be improved
- How hardware designers improve performance
- What is parallel processing

Understanding Performance

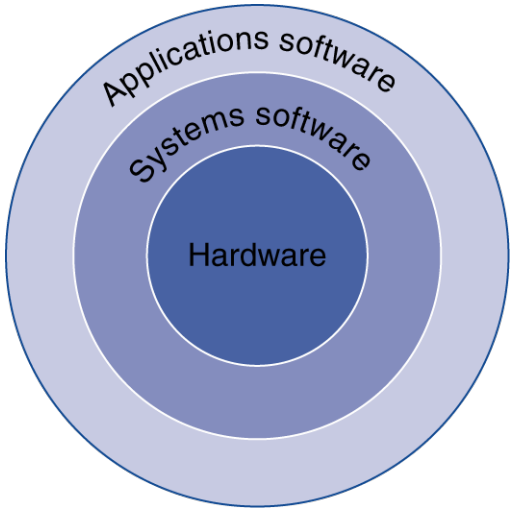
- Algorithm
  - Determines number of operations executed
- Programming language, compiler, architecture
  - Determine number of machine instructions executed per operation
- Processor and memory system
  - Determine how fast instructions are executed
- I/O system (including OS)
  - Determines how fast I/O operations are executed

Seven Great Ideas

- Use ***abstraction*** to simplify design
- Make the ***common case fast***
- Performance *via* ***parallelism***
- Performance *via* ***pipelining***
- Performance *via* ***prediction***
- ***Hierarchy*** of memories
- ***Dependability*** *via* redundancy



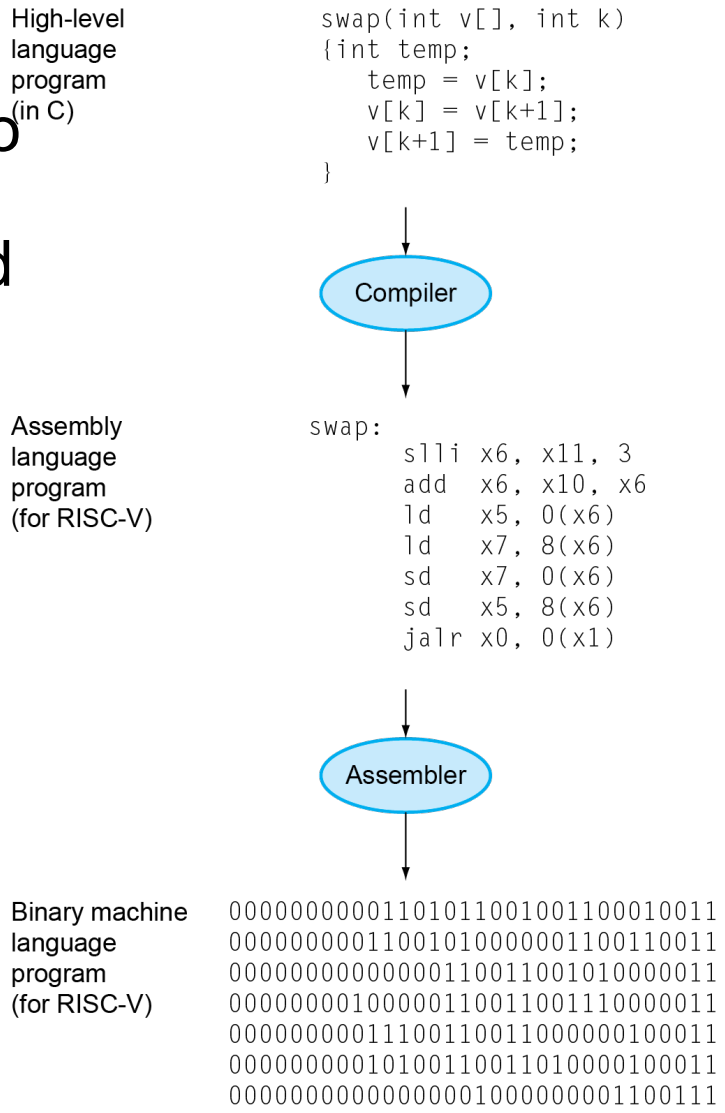
Below Your Program



- Application software
  - Written in high-level language
- System software
  - Compiler: translates HLL code to machine code
  - Operating System: service code
    - Handling input/output
    - Managing memory and storage
    - Scheduling tasks & sharing resources
- Hardware
  - Processor, memory, I/O controllers

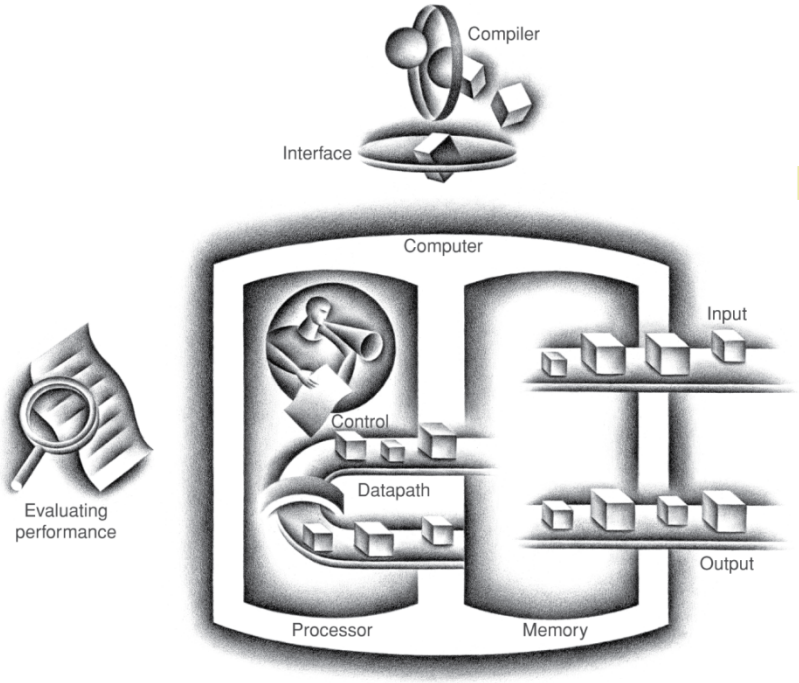
Levels of Program Code

- High-level language
  - Level of abstraction closer to problem domain
  - Provides for productivity and portability
- Assembly language
  - Textual representation of instructions
- Hardware representation
  - Binary digits (bits)
  - Encoded instructions and data



Components of a Computer

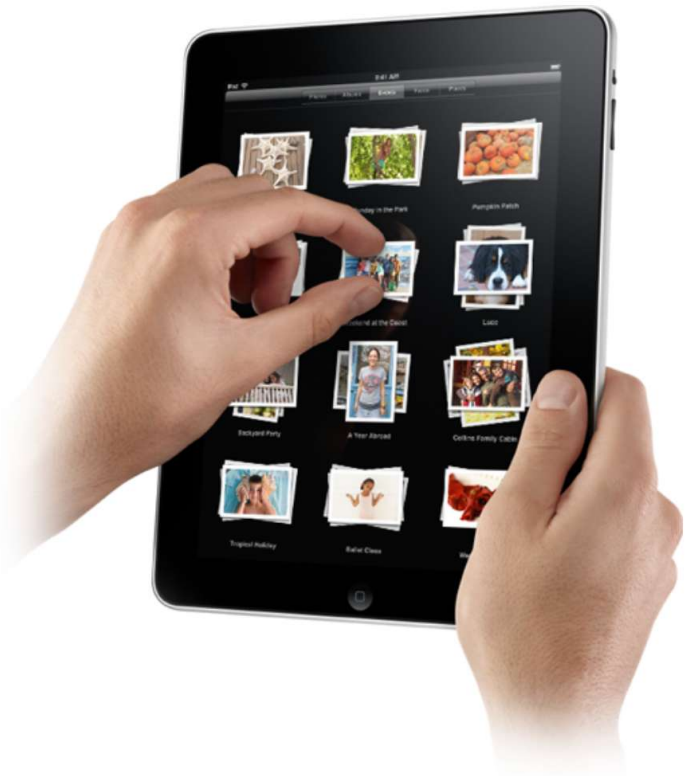
The BIG Picture



- Same components for all kinds of computer
  - Desktop, server, embedded
- Input/output includes
  - User-interface devices
    - Display, keyboard, mouse
  - Storage devices
    - Hard disk, CD/DVD, flash
  - Network adapters
    - For communicating with other computers

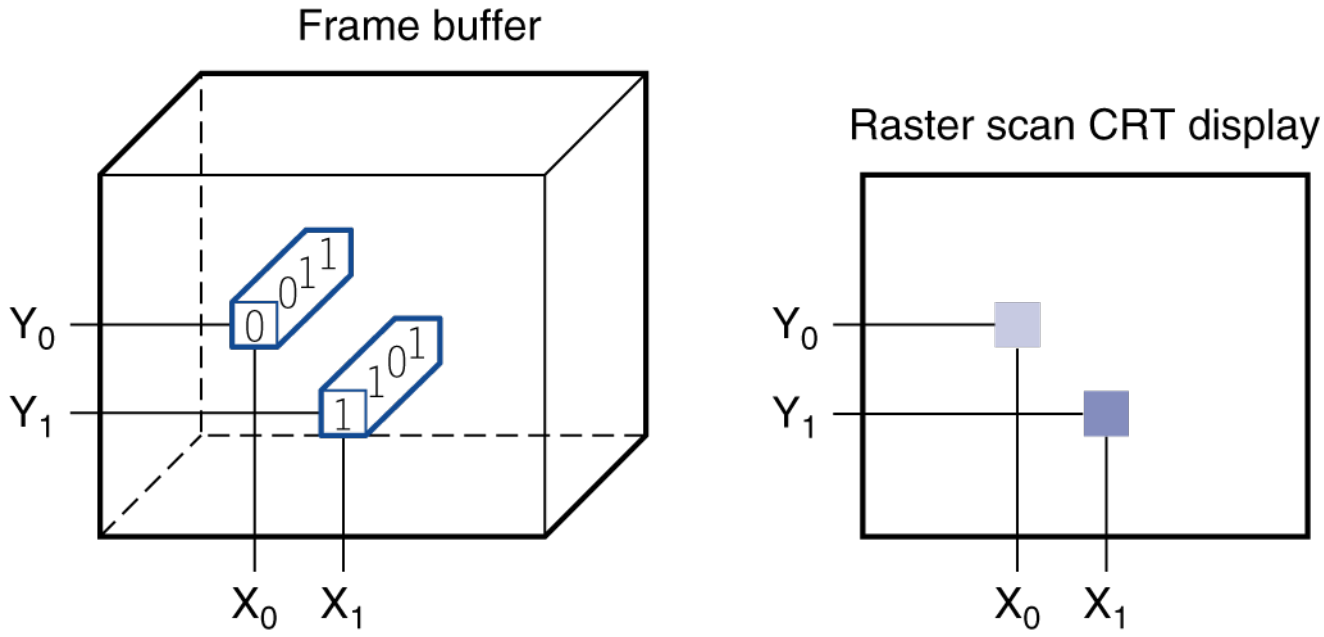
Touchscreen

- PostPC device
- Supersedes keyboard and mouse
- Resistive and Capacitive types
  - Most tablets, smart phones use capacitive
  - Capacitive allows multiple touches simultaneously

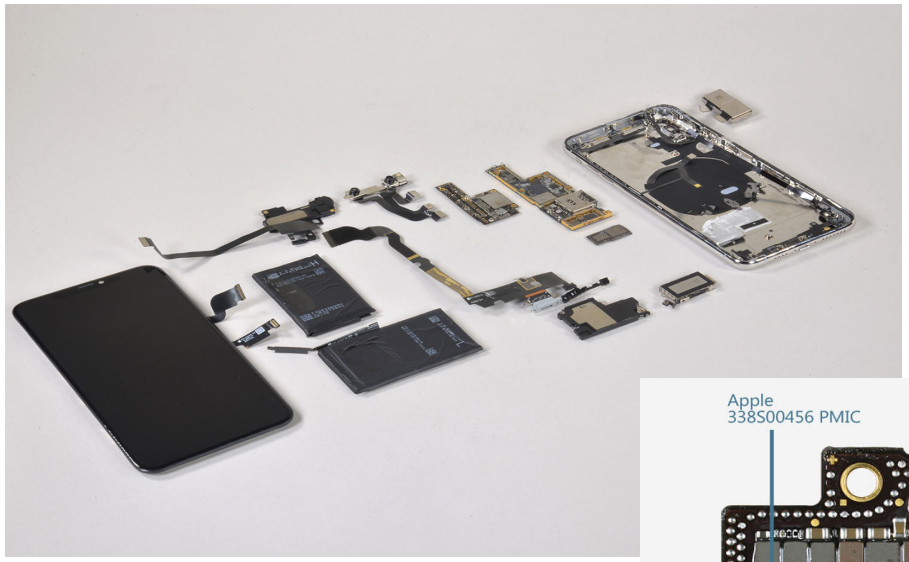


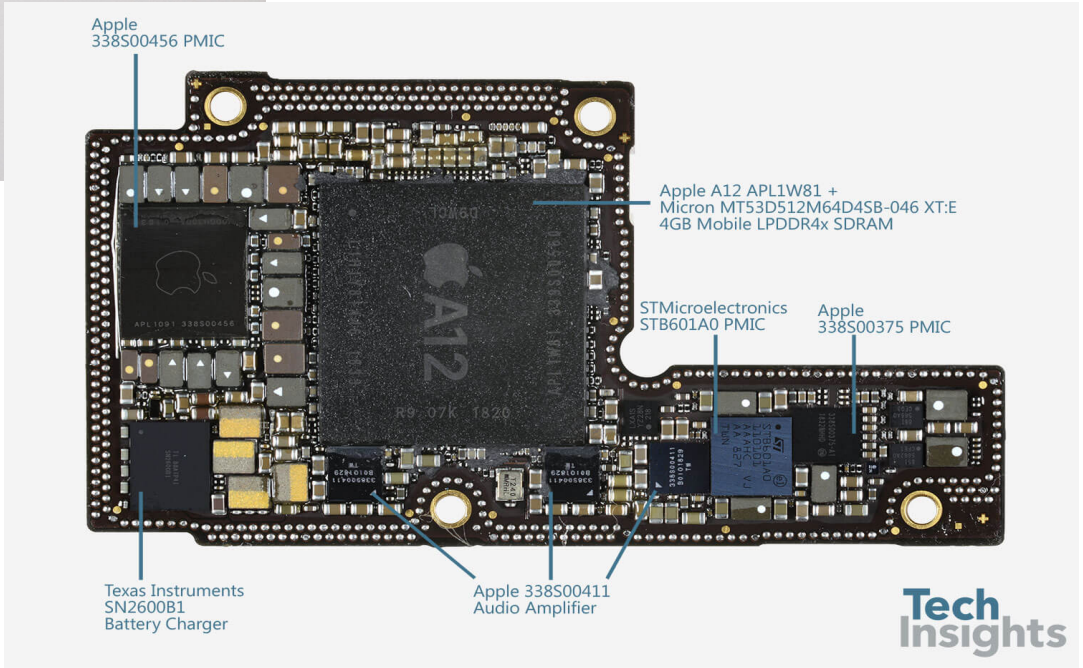
Through the Looking Glass

- LCD screen: picture elements (pixels)
  - Mirrors content of frame buffer memory



Opening the Box



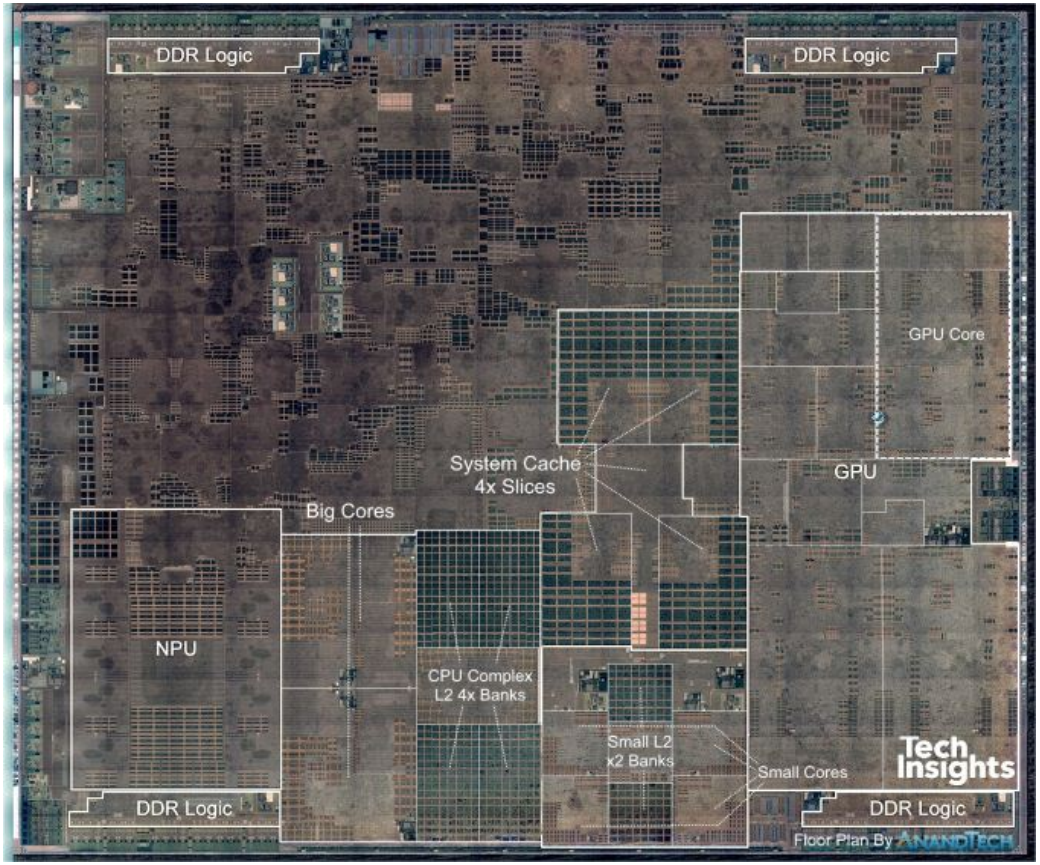


Inside the Processor (CPU)

- Datapath: performs operations on data
- Control: sequences datapath, memory, ...
- Cache memory
  - Small fast SRAM memory for immediate access to data

Inside the Processor

- A12 processor



Abstractions

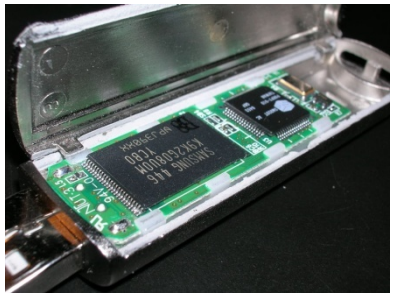
The BIG Picture

- Abstraction helps us deal with complexity
  - Hide lower-level detail
- Instruction set architecture (ISA)
  - The hardware/software interface
- Application binary interface
  - The ISA plus system software interface
- Implementation
  - The details underlying and interface

A Safe Place for Data

- Volatile main memory
  - Loses instructions and data when power off
- Non-volatile secondary memory
  - Magnetic disk
  - Flash memory
  - Optical disk (CDROM, DVD)





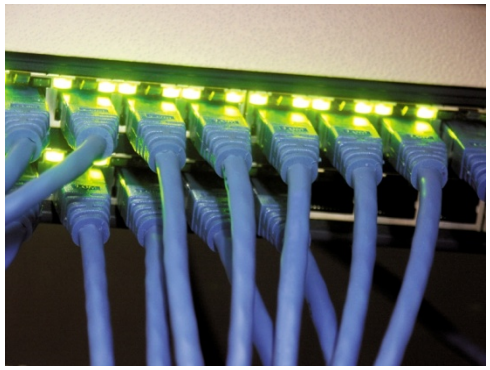




Networks

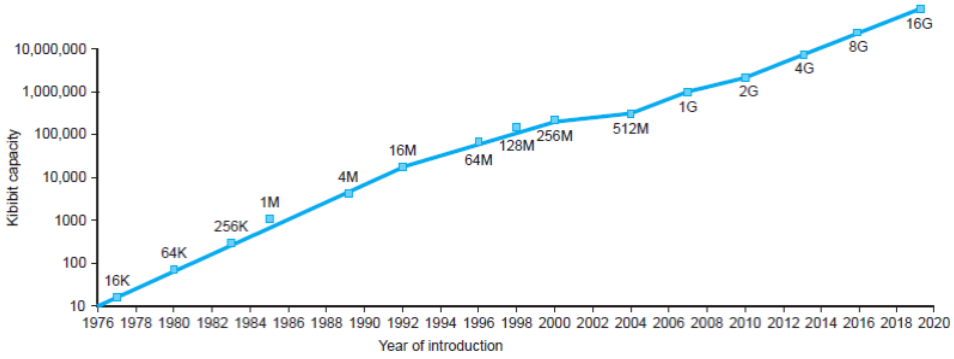
- Communication, resource sharing, nonlocal access
- Local area network (LAN): Ethernet
- Wide area network (WAN): the Internet
- Wireless network: WiFi, Bluetooth





Technology Trends

- Electronics technology continues to evolve
  - Increased capacity and performance
  - Reduced cost



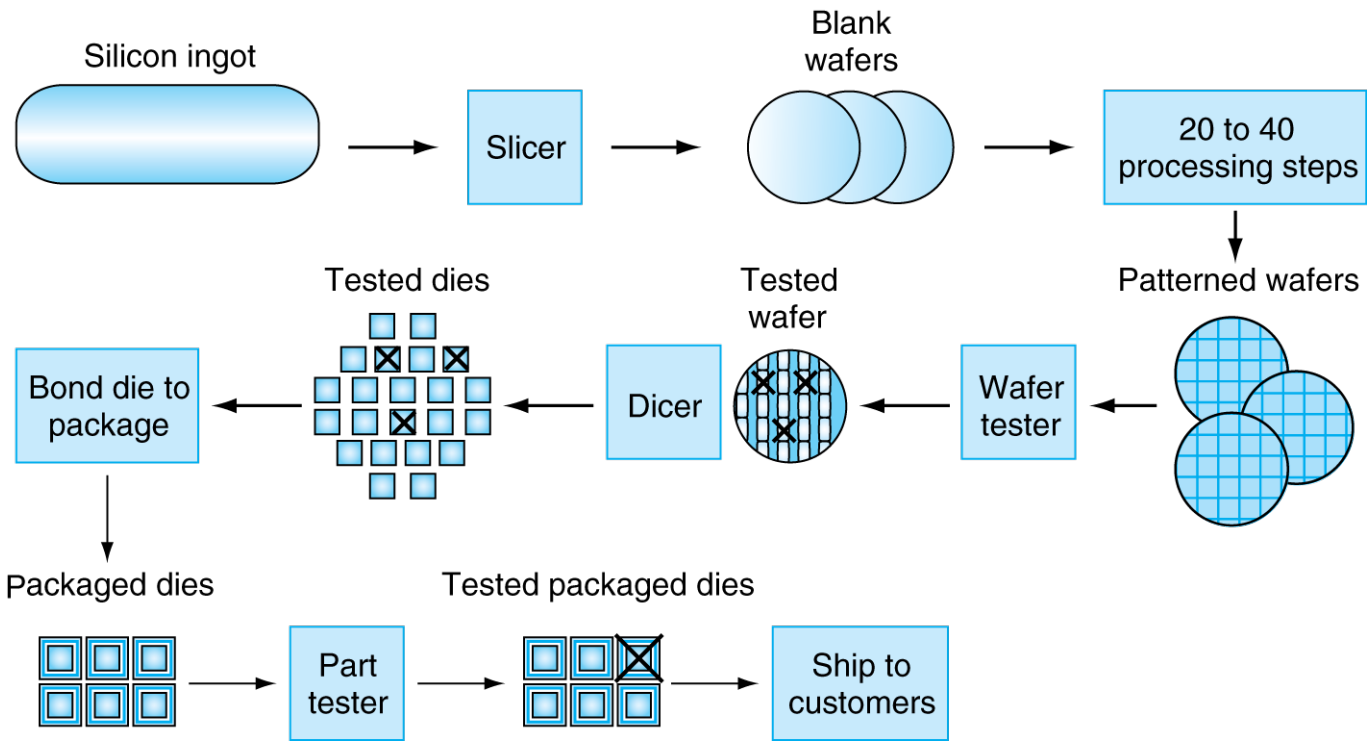
DRAM capacity

Year	Technology	Relative performance/cost
1951	Vacuum tube	1
1965	Transistor	35
1975	Integrated circuit (IC)	900
1995	Very large scale IC (VLSI)	2,400,000
2013	Ultra large scale IC	250,000,000,000

Semiconductor Technology

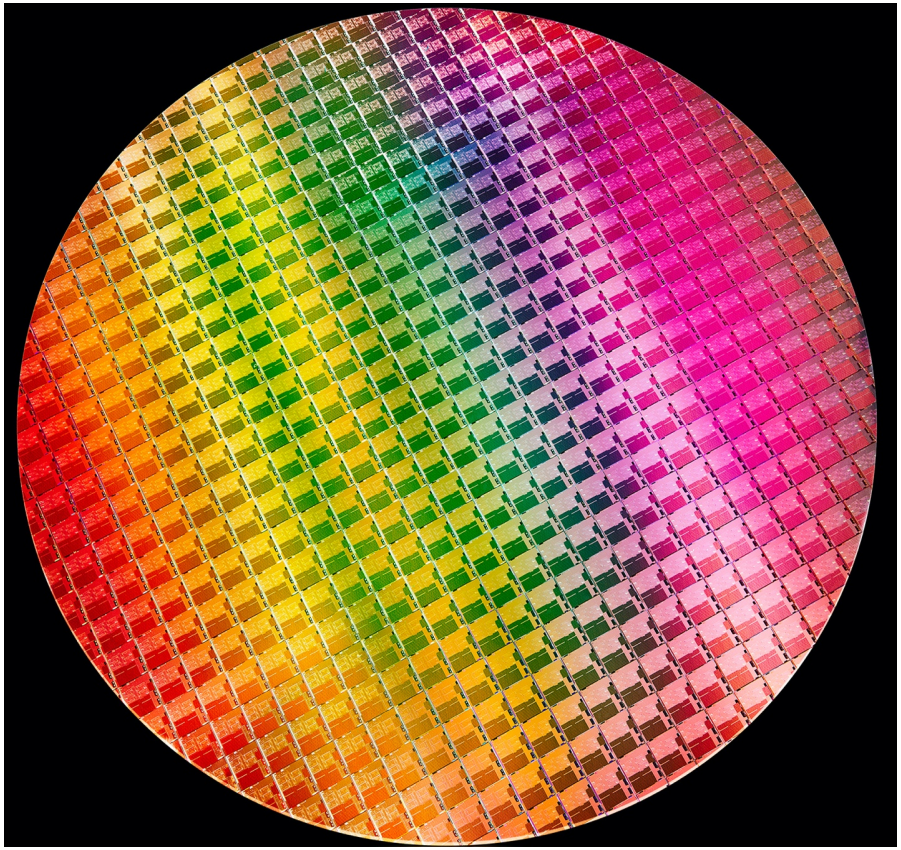
- Silicon: semiconductor
- Add materials to transform properties:
  - Conductors
  - Insulators
  - Switch

Manufacturing ICs



- Yield: proportion of working dies per wafer

Intel® Core 10th Gen



- 300mm wafer, 506 chips, 10nm technology
- Each chip is 11.4 x 10.7 mm

Integrated Circuit Cost

$$\text{Cost per die} = \frac{\text{Cost per wafer}}{\text{Dies per wafer} \times \text{Yield}}$$

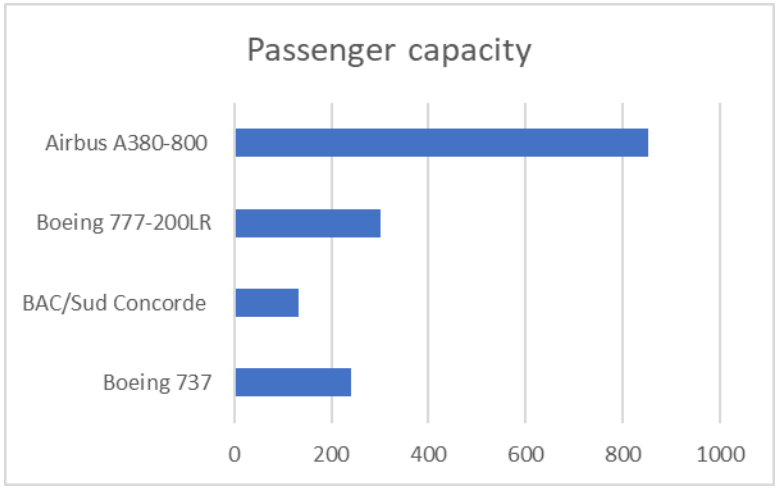
$$\text{Dies per wafer} \approx \text{Wafer area}/\text{Die area}$$

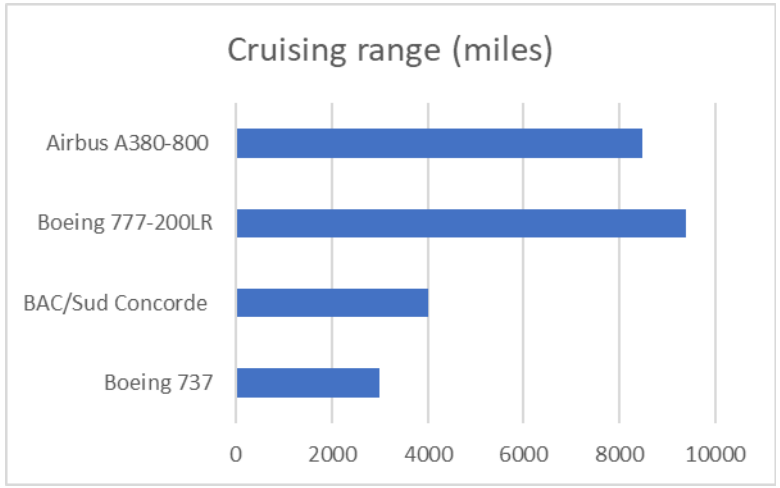
$$\text{Yield} = \frac{1}{(1 + (\text{Defects per area} \times \text{Die area}/2))^2}$$

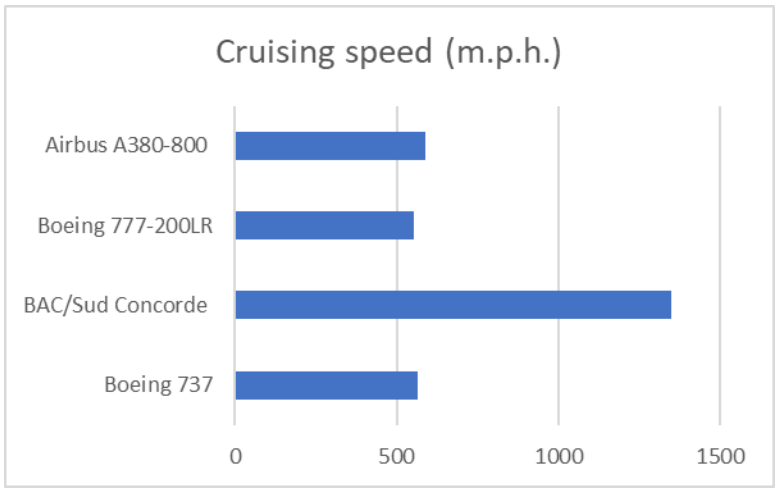
- Nonlinear relation to area and defect rate
  - Wafer cost and area are fixed
  - Defect rate determined by manufacturing process
  - Die area determined by architecture and circuit design

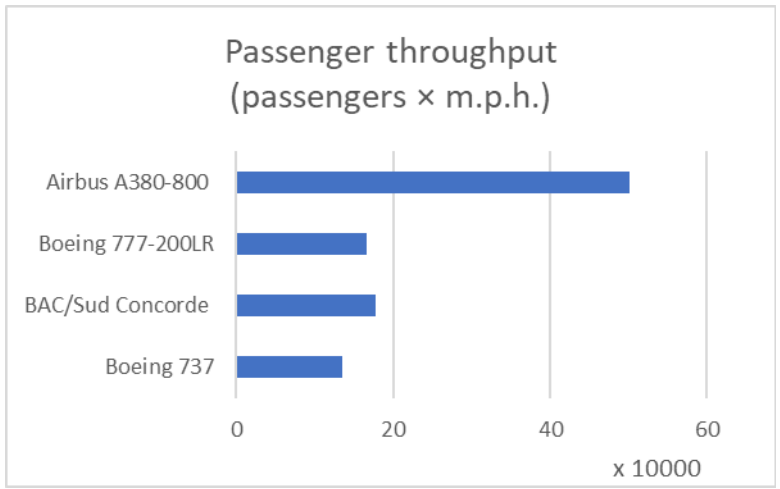
Defining Performance

- Which airplane has the best performance?









Response Time and Throughput

- Response time
  - How long it takes to do a task
- Throughput
  - Total work done per unit time
    - e.g., tasks/transactions/… per hour
- How are response time and throughput affected by
  - Replacing the processor with a faster version?
  - Adding more processors?
- We'll focus on response time for now…

Relative Performance

- Define Performance = 1/Execution Time
- "X is n time faster than Y"

$$\text{Performance}_X / \text{Performance}_Y$$
$$= \text{Execution time}_Y / \text{Execution time}_X = n$$

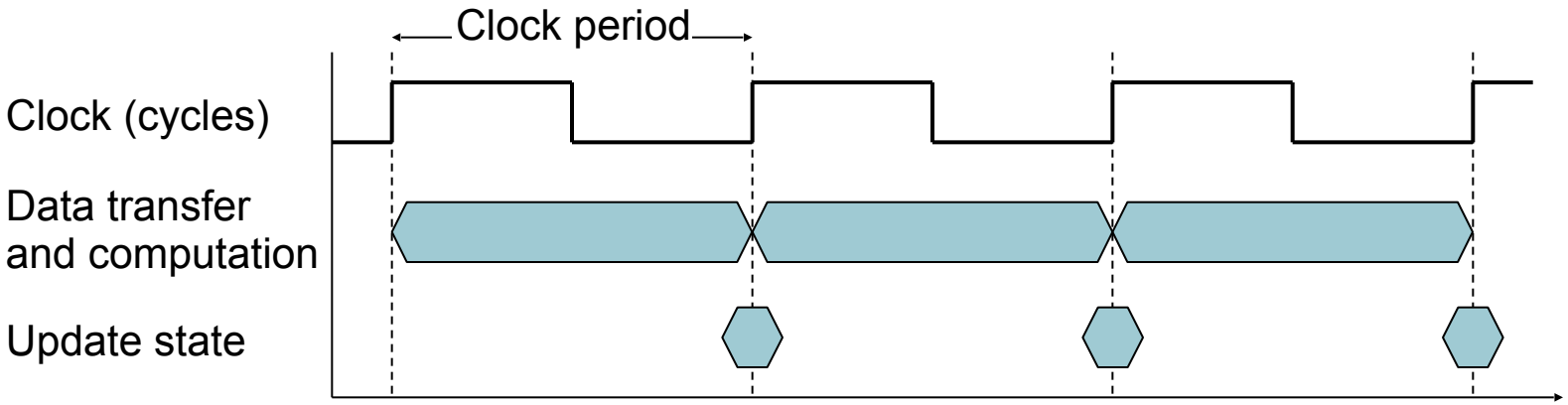
- Example: time taken to run a program
  - 10s on A, 15s on B
  - Execution Time_B / Execution Time_A
    = 15s / 10s = 1.5
  - So A is 1.5 times faster than B

Measuring Execution Time

- Elapsed time
  - Total response time, including all aspects
    - Processing, I/O, OS overhead, idle time
  - Determines system performance
- CPU time
  - Time spent processing a given job
    - Discounts I/O time, other jobs' shares
  - Comprises user CPU time and system CPU time
  - Different programs are affected differently by CPU and system performance

CPU Clocking

- Operation of digital hardware governed by a constant-rate clock



  - Clock period: duration of a clock cycle
    - e.g., 250ps = 0.25ns = 250×10^{-12}s
  - Clock frequency (rate): cycles per second
    - e.g., 4.0GHz = 4000MHz = 4.0×10^{9}Hz

CPU Time

$$\text{CPU Time} = \text{CPU Clock Cycles} \times \text{Clock Cycle Time}$$

$$= \frac{\text{CPU Clock Cycles}}{\text{Clock Rate}}$$

- Performance improved by
  - Reducing number of clock cycles
  - Increasing clock rate
  - Hardware designer must often trade off clock rate against cycle count

CPU Time Example

- Computer A: 2GHz clock, 10s CPU time
- Designing Computer B
  - Aim for 6s CPU time
  - Can do faster clock, but causes 1.2 × clock cycles
- How fast must Computer B clock be?

$$\text{Clock Rate}_B = \frac{\text{Clock Cycles}_B}{\text{CPU Time}_B} = \frac{1.2 \times \text{Clock Cycles}_A}{6\text{s}}$$

$$\text{Clock Cycles}_A = \text{CPU Time}_A \times \text{Clock Rate}_A$$

$$= 10\text{s} \times 2\text{GHz} = 20 \times 10^9$$

$$\text{Clock Rate}_B = \frac{1.2 \times 20 \times 10^9}{6\text{s}} = \frac{24 \times 10^9}{6\text{s}} = 4\text{GHz}$$

Instruction Count and CPI

$$\text{Clock Cycles} = \text{Instruction Count} \times \text{Cycles per Instruction}$$

$$\text{CPU Time} = \text{Instruction Count} \times \text{CPI} \times \text{Clock Cycle Time}$$

$$= \frac{\text{Instruction Count} \times \text{CPI}}{\text{Clock Rate}}$$

- Instruction Count for a program
  - Determined by program, ISA and compiler
- Average cycles per instruction
  - Determined by CPU hardware
  - If different instructions have different CPI
    - Average CPI affected by instruction mix

CPI Example

- Computer A: Cycle Time = 250ps, CPI = 2.0
- Computer B: Cycle Time = 500ps, CPI = 1.2
- Same ISA
- Which is faster, and by how much?

$$\text{CPU Time}_A = \text{Instruction Count} \times \text{CPI}_A \times \text{Cycle Time}_A$$
$$= I \times 2.0 \times 250\text{ps} = I \times 500\text{ps}$$

A is faster…

$$\text{CPU Time}_B = \text{Instruction Count} \times \text{CPI}_B \times \text{Cycle Time}_B$$
$$= I \times 1.2 \times 500\text{ps} = I \times 600\text{ps}$$

$$\frac{\text{CPU Time}_B}{\text{CPU Time}_A} = \frac{I \times 600\text{ps}}{I \times 500\text{ps}} = 1.2$$

…by this much

CPI in More Detail

- If different instruction classes take different numbers of cycles

$$\text{Clock Cycles} = \sum_{i=1}^{n} (\text{CPI}_i \times \text{Instruction Count}_i)$$

  - Weighted average CPI

$$\text{CPI} = \frac{\text{Clock Cycles}}{\text{Instruction Count}} = \sum_{i=1}^{n} \left(\text{CPI}_i \times \underbrace{\frac{\text{Instruction Count}_i}{\text{Instruction Count}}}_{\text{Relative frequency}} \right)$$

CPI Example

- Alternative compiled code sequences using instructions in classes A, B, C

Class	A	B	C
CPI for class	1	2	3
IC in sequence 1	2	1	2
IC in sequence 2	4	1	1

- Sequence 1: IC = 5
  - Clock Cycles
    = 2×1 + 1×2 + 2×3
    = 10
  - Avg. CPI = 10/5 = 2.0
- Sequence 2: IC = 6
  - Clock Cycles
    = 4×1 + 1×2 + 1×3
    = 9
  - Avg. CPI = 9/6 = 1.5

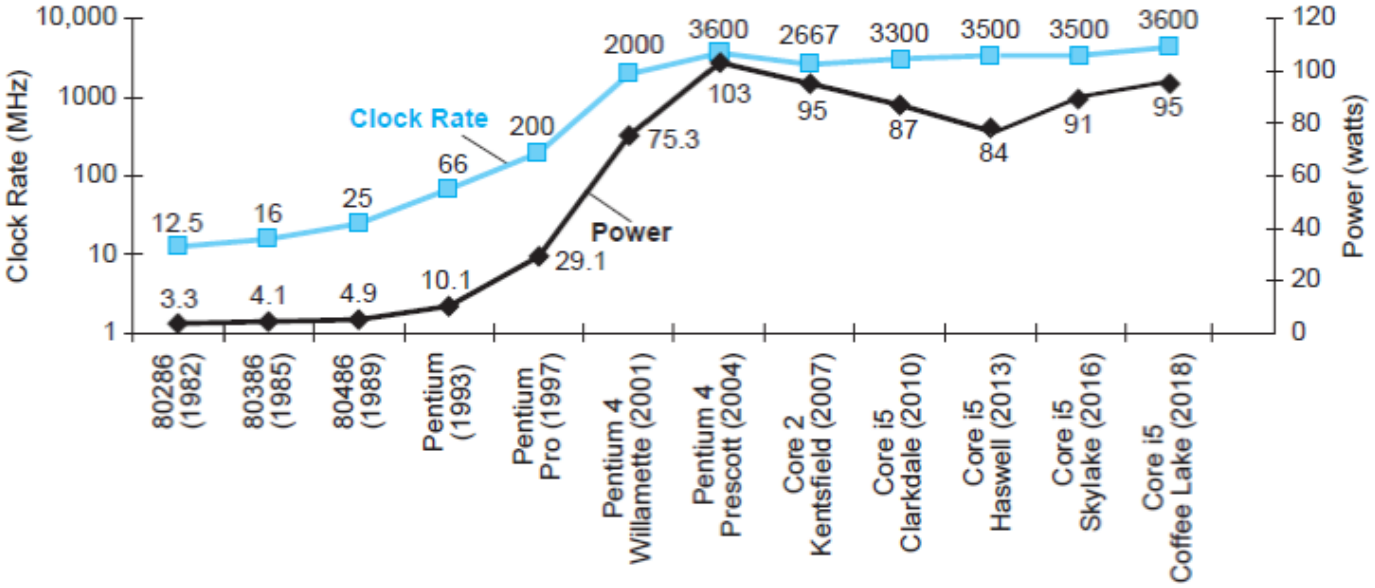
Performance Summary

The BIG Picture

$$\text{CPU Time} = \frac{\text{Instructions}}{\text{Program}} \times \frac{\text{Clock cycles}}{\text{Instruction}} \times \frac{\text{Seconds}}{\text{Clock cycle}}$$

- Performance depends on
  - Algorithm: affects IC, possibly CPI
  - Programming language: affects IC, CPI
  - Compiler: affects IC, CPI
  - Instruction set architecture: affects IC, CPI, T_c

Power Trends



- In CMOS IC technology

$$\text{Power} = \text{Capacitive load} \times \text{Voltage}^2 \times \text{Frequency}$$

×30 | 5V → 1V | ×1000

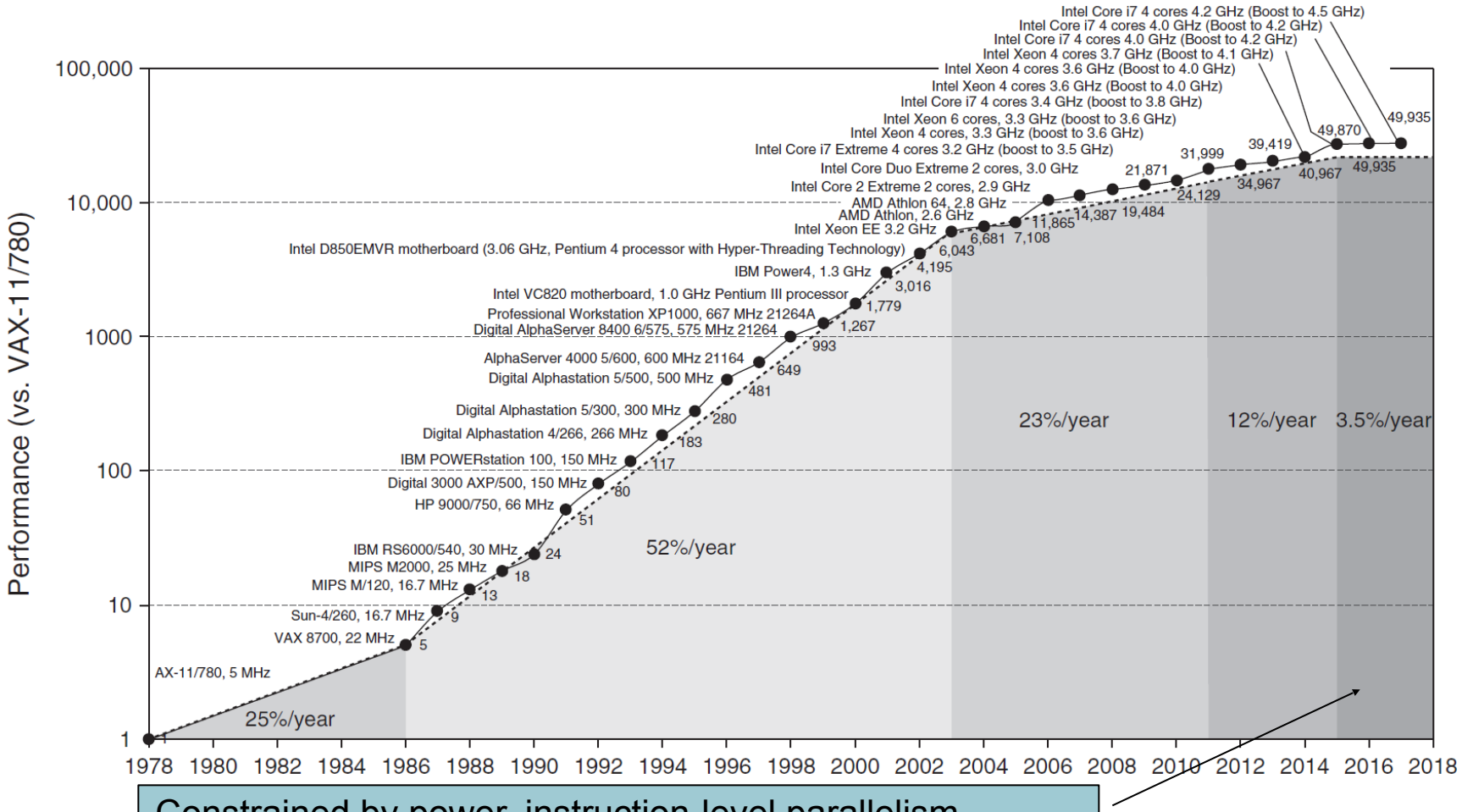
Reducing Power

- Suppose a new CPU has
  - 85% of capacitive load of old CPU
  - 15% voltage and 15% frequency reduction

$$\frac{P_{new}}{P_{old}} = \frac{C_{old} \times 0.85 \times (V_{old} \times 0.85)^2 \times F_{old} \times 0.85}{C_{old} \times V_{old}^{\ 2} \times F_{old}} = 0.85^4 = 0.52$$

- The power wall
  - We can't reduce voltage further
  - We can't remove more heat
- How else can we improve performance?

Uniprocessor Performance



Constrained by power, instruction-level parallelism, memory latency

Multiprocessors

- Multicore microprocessors
  - More than one processor per chip
- Requires explicitly parallel programming
  - Compare with instruction level parallelism
    - Hardware executes multiple instructions at once
    - Hidden from the programmer
  - Hard to do
    - Programming for performance
    - Load balancing
    - Optimizing communication and synchronization

SPEC CPU Benchmark

- Programs used to measure performance
  - Supposedly typical of actual workload
- Standard Performance Evaluation Corp (SPEC)
  - Develops benchmarks for CPU, I/O, Web, …
- SPEC CPU2006
  - Elapsed time to execute a selection of programs
    - Negligible I/O, so focuses on CPU performance
  - Normalize relative to reference machine
  - Summarize as geometric mean of performance ratios
    - CINT2006 (integer) and CFP2006 (floating-point)

$$\sqrt[n]{\prod_{i=1}^{n} \text{Execution time ratio}_i}$$

SPECspeed 2017 Integer benchmarks on a 1.8 GHz Intel Xeon E5-2650L

Description	*Name*	*Instruction Count x 10^9*	*CPI*	*Clock cycle time (seconds x 10^–9)*	*Execution Time (seconds)*	*Reference Time (seconds)*	*SPECratio*
Perl interpreter	perlbench	2684	0.42	0.556	627	1774	2.83
GNU C compiler	gcc	2322	0.67	0.556	863	3976	4.61
Route planning	mcf	1786	1.22	0.556	1215	4721	3.89
Discrete Event simulation - computer network	omnetpp	1107	0.82	0.556	507	1630	3.21
XML to HTML conversion via XSLT	xalancbmk	1314	0.75	0.556	549	1417	2.58
Video compression	x264	4488	0.32	0.556	813	1763	2.17
Artificial Intelligence: alpha-beta tree search (Chess)	deepsjeng	2216	0.57	0.556	698	1432	2.05
Artificial Intelligence: Monte Carlo tree search (Go)	leela	2236	0.79	0.556	987	1703	1.73
Artificial Intelligence: recursive solution generator (Sudoku)	exchange2	6683	0.46	0.556	1718	2939	1.71
General data compression	xz	8533	1.32	0.556	6290	6182	0.98
Geometric mean							2.36

SPEC Power Benchmark

- Power consumption of server at different workload levels
  - Performance: ssj_ops/sec
  - Power: Watts (Joules/sec)

$$\text{Overall ssj_ops per Watt} = \left(\sum_{i=0}^{10} \text{ssj_ops}_i\right) \Big/ \left(\sum_{i=0}^{10} \text{power}_i\right)$$

SPECpower_ssj2008 for Xeon E5-2650L

Target Load %	Performance (ssj_ops)	Average Power (watts)
100%	4,864,136	347
90%	4,389,196	312
80%	3,905,724	278
70%	3,418,737	241
60%	2,925,811	212
50%	2,439,017	183
40%	1,951,394	160
30%	1,461,411	141
20%	974,045	128
10%	485,973	115
0%	0	48
Overall Sum	26,815,444	2,165
∑ssj_ops / ∑power =		12,385

Pitfall: Amdahl's Law

- Improving an aspect of a computer and expecting a proportional improvement in overall performance

$$T_{\text{improved}} = \frac{T_{\text{affected}}}{\text{improvement factor}} + T_{\text{unaffected}}$$

- Example: multiply accounts for 80s/100s
  - How much improvement in multiply performance to get 5× overall?

$$20 = \frac{80}{n} + 20$$

  - Can't be done!

- Corollary: make the common case fast

Fallacy: Low Power at Idle

- Look back at i7 power benchmark
  - At 100% load: 258W
  - At 50% load: 170W (66%)
  - At 10% load: 121W (47%)
- Google data center
  - Mostly operates at 10% – 50% load
  - At 100% load less than 1% of the time
- Consider designing processors to make power proportional to load

Pitfall: MIPS as a Performance Metric

- MIPS: Millions of Instructions Per Second
  - Doesn't account for
    - Differences in ISAs between computers
    - Differences in complexity between instructions

$$\text{MIPS} = \frac{\text{Instruction count}}{\text{Execution time} \times 10^6}$$

$$= \frac{\text{Instruction count}}{\frac{\text{Instruction count} \times \text{CPI}}{\text{Clock rate}} \times 10^6} = \frac{\text{Clock rate}}{\text{CPI} \times 10^6}$$

  - CPI varies between programs on a given CPU

Concluding Remarks

- Cost/performance is improving
  - Due to underlying technology development
- Hierarchical layers of abstraction
  - In both hardware and software
- Instruction set architecture
  - The hardware/software interface
- Execution time: the best performance measure
- Power is a limiting factor
  - Use parallelism to improve performance